

Death in A Northern Town. The 'Derry
Civil War.' June 1920: A study by
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Death in a Northern Town

This is a local history study about the city of Derry. It is a narrative account of the violent incidents at the sectarian interface areas throughout 1920 that gradually culminated in a civil war within the confines of the city. The study gives an account derived mostly from primary sources of events that have not been widely written about. Most primary source materials utilised here are newspaper articles. The focus has been mainly on court cases such as inquests and trials. It is felt that such texts are likely to be more reliable and focused on obtaining accurate accounts. The study will begin with a brief overview of political developments early in the year and will give some examples of unionist reactions to those developments and furthermore, it will demonstrate the republican and nationalist responses to those violent unionist reactions. The study will focus upon eight of the twenty-two victims killed in the riots and gun battles as a case study. This short study in no way wishes to appear to lessen the importance of the remaining victims. However, time and space does not permit a complete evaluation of all those killed and wounded in the events of the spring and summer of that year. Armed groups involved in the battles, riots or war are often referred to as Orangemen and armed unionists. These were the Ulster Volunteer Force. Likewise, Irish Volunteers were the Irish Republican Army. The study will endeavour to demonstrate similarities between this miniature war and previous military conflict in the city and its environs. The issue of British crown forces' partisanship will be discussed briefly. Not least because the argument

pervades many of the primary and secondary sources employed in the synthesis of this short study.

On a Tuesday evening in June 1920, a ball rolled down Fountain Street in Derry. It continued its journey across Carlisle Road and into Bridge Street. Some children were playing in Bridge Street and they took possession of the ball. The children who owned the ball had followed it downhill from Fountain Street and as they attempted to regain possession of it, an altercation developed. Before long, adults became involved in the fight. The two groups began throwing stones at each other and as night approached, revolvers were produced, and the most incessant and prolonged shooting orgy ever experienced in the city ensued. Revolver fire was concentrated in the Carlisle Road area. People using the thoroughfare fled in terror. Rifles were produced, and sniping was indulged in from Fountain Street. Street lights were extinguished, probably to obscure the view of snipers. The snipers delivered rapid and sustained volleys at anyone that moved in their target areas. The shooting spread to several other streets and did not remain confined to the Carlisle Road area. One man was fortunate to survive when a bullet ricocheted off a wall, penetrated his coat, grazed his skin and settled in his pocket where it was later discovered.¹ That man was lucky to escape with his life. Two men had lost their lives

¹“Fight for a Ball.” *Freeman’s Journal*, June 17, 1920, 3.

during similar disturbances one month earlier.² However, the fight for a ball was not merely a fight for a ball. It was the spark that ignited the latest of many disturbances in Derry that year.

The two streets mentioned above, Fountain Street and Bridge Street were built, abutting the city walls, near the arched entry to the walled city that is known as Ferryquay Gate. Ferryquay Gate is one of the four original gates of the walled city that was built between 1613 and 1618. Cabins on the site of Fountain Street originally housed 'lowly Presbyterians'³ who had fought bravely during the Great Siege of 1688 to 1689 and the remainder of the subsequent Williamite War. However, following the Treaty of Limerick and the enforcement of the Penal Laws, Presbyterians experienced similar discrimination to the Catholics. Presbyterians and Catholics were compelled to live outside the Anglican controlled walled city.⁴ The bottom of Fountain Street faced into the existential Catholic Bridge Street⁵ and the top of Fountain Street faced across Bishop Street to the Catholic Long Tower Street.⁶ The top and the bottom of Fountain Street were interface areas. The sectarian

² "Desperate Rioting in Derry City: Detective and Ex-Soldier Dead; Many Wounded; Three Nights of Fierce Conflict; Masked Orangemen Hold up Passers-By." *The Irish Independent*, May 17, 1920, 5.

³ Mickey Cooper, *Bishop Street and The Fountain: A Shared History* (Derry: Gasyard Heritage Centre, 2015), 12.

⁴ Ibid

⁵ Bridge Street was at that time, a Catholic district. Whilst some residential housing remains there, most buildings are now commercial or sheltered housing schemes.

⁶ None of the houses or commercial buildings that existed in 1920 remain in this part of Long Tower Street. A fence is in place since 1970, separating Fountain Street from the Bishop Street and Long Tower areas.

segregation of the city was generally referred to by the media in 1920 as the Orange quarters and Sinn Féin quarters. These generalisations allowed journalists to give less complicated narrative accounts of events in this period.

On the 30th January 1920 the municipal elections returned a nationalist majority in Derry and subsequently a nationalist mayor for the first time since 1688. This was traumatic for the unionists of the city. Derry holds a special place in Orange mythology. It is a planters' citadel that held out for William of Orange in the Great Siege of 1688 to 1689 against the Catholic convert, King James II. The original walled city was built on high ground overlooking the Catholic Bogside, a ghetto that sprung up on the low lying marshy ground below.⁷ The first nationalist mayor and nationalist corporation were installed since James II appointed Cormac O' Neill over two hundred and thirty years earlier. The maiden city had finally fallen to nationalists with a 21 to 19 majority.⁸ This corporation voted their allegiance to the Dáil and the republican government.⁹ To local nationalists, the Derry victory would impede partition or, failing that, it would make it more difficult to have the city of Derry included in the partitioned six county state.

⁷ Michael Farrell, *Northern Ireland: The Orange State* (2nd Ed.) (London: Pluto Press, 1980), 21-38.

⁸ Colm Fox, "Towards Partition." *The Making of a Minority: Political Developments in Derry and the North 1912-25* (Derry: Guildhall Press, 1997), <http://cain.ulst.ac.uk/othelem/fox.htm> (accessed March 22, 2018).

⁹ Farrell, 21-38.

Hugh C. O' Doherty, a local solicitor became Derry's first citizen, and head of the nationalist corporation. Within a week of his selection, British military and police extensively raided nationalist areas of the city. Arms, explosives and ammunition were seized. Ronan Gallagher argues that only nationalist areas were targeted in these raids. This was despite police intelligence that almost every unionist of all ages carried a revolver. Moreover, several Sinn Féin members were arrested and moved to Mountjoy Gaol in Dublin.¹⁰ Furthermore, Gallagher draws attention to how Derry was horrified by the news of the mayor of Cork Tomas Mac Curtain's killing in March 1920. The city's nationalist population feared that Derry's new mayor might be a target for similar treatment. What is more, a death threat to Wexford's mayor added to the growing tension.¹¹ When republicans or nationalists attained success through the ballot box, it appeared, they were being assassinated or imprisoned. In fact, some nationalist elected representatives were at that time held in Derry Gaol, including MPs Joseph Sweeney and P.J. Ward.¹² Alderman O' Doherty tabled motions to remove party trappings from official buildings and functions. This was followed by sectarian attacks by and threats from the Ulster Volunteer Force on Catholics. These factors together with IRA attacks on crown forces, in the nearby countryside ensured that Derry remained extremely tense from the end of January onwards.¹³

¹⁰ Ronan Gallagher, *Violence and nationalist politics in Derry City, 1920-1923* (Dublin: Four Courts Press, 2003), 20-42.

¹¹ Ibid.

¹² Ibid.

¹³ Ibid.

Rioting broke out in Derry on Saturday night April 17th when British soldiers were attacked by a crowd and pursued to a Soldiers' Club where they sheltered. The club came under attack and military reinforcements were summoned to the scene. Together with police support, five hundred soldiers used bayonets to charge the crowd who reportedly used stones and revolver shots against the crown forces. The police barracks at Lecky Road was subsequently attacked, reportedly by a crowd using stones and revolvers. Again, police and military reinforcements arrived, and resistance was offered. In the ensuing fight, eleven civilians sustained injuries. A total of fifty injuries were reported that night. Unionists and Sinn Féiners fought the following night and revolvers were again used. There were further casualties and police and military eventually cleared the streets.¹⁴ However, serious as these incidents were, by May that year, they were to become much worse.

Bernard Doherty left his Anne Street home at about eight o' clock on Sunday 16th May 1920. When his father, John next saw Bernard, he was dead. Twenty-one-year-old Bernard, an ex-soldier went into the city centre with his friend Patrick Starrs. Starrs paused in Ferryquay Street where he learned that there was rioting in Carlisle

¹⁴"Derry Riots: Four Hours' Fierce Street Fighting; Many Bayonet Charges; Renewal on Sunday Night Faction Fight." *The Liberator*, April 20, 1920.

Road, a short distance away beyond Ferryquay Gate. Bernard Doherty went down Linenhall Street. Within a few minutes Patrick Starrs heard that a man had been shot in Linenhall Street. Starrs and some other people ran to where the man lay. It was Bernard Doherty. When Doherty heard Starrs' voice he said, 'Paddy I'm shot.' He had been shot with a revolver bullet fired from the vicinity of Ferryquay Gate. The bullet had done some damage to the heart and serious damage to the liver. He died of internal haemorrhage and shock. The coroner at this inquest condemned the hooliganism, rowdyism and blackguardism that had been indulged in throughout the city. The coroner expressed sympathy with the deceased's bereaved family. The twenty-one-year-old, despite his youth was a war veteran. He had been gassed and wounded but had survived his injuries. His brother, Private William John Doherty of 1st Battalion Royal Irish Fusiliers was killed on May 23rd, 1915 and was buried in Turkey. Bernard returned home to Derry.¹⁵ He had survived the war only to be felled by an assassin's bullet in his home town.

There had been rioting that weekend on three consecutive nights. A loyalist crowd attacked Bridge Street on the night of Friday 14th May, shouting that the attack was to avenge the wounding of a Protestant clergyman in Downpatrick. That excuse on the night was enough to ignite the 'fiercest riot yet experienced in Derry, remarkable

¹⁵ *The Derry People*, Saturday, May 22, 1920.

for the bitterness of its political conflicts.’¹⁶ Shots were fired on all three nights as well as stones, bottles and other missiles thrown. On Saturday night when fighting broke out, mostly between women from Fountain Street and Bridge Street, bottles and stones were used to bombard each other. The riot was sparked by a drunk Orangeman staggering into Bridge Street using offensive epithets. He was set upon and beaten. Catholics received the same maltreatment in the Fountain Street area. Police quelled the riot for three hours, but it re-ignited at about 9pm. At one stage during the renewed violence about a hundred revolver rounds were fired across Carlisle Road between the two streets. A large body of police arrived and charged after the Catholics down Bridge Street. The charge continued to the quay. During a gun battle several police and civilians were hurt. Detective Denis Moroney died of a bullet wound. Among the injured was an ex-soldier called John Mc Callion. On the Saturday and the Sunday when Bernard Doherty was killed, armed and masked ‘Unionist ex-soldiers’¹⁷ also known as ‘The Civilian Guard’¹⁸ took control of the Carlisle Bridge and beat any Catholics that they could identify as such. Furthermore, they fired shots at a car forcing the driver to stop. He was permitted to proceed when it was ascertained that he was a Protestant.¹⁹ The weekend in May described here gives a flavour of the tension that pervaded Derry at that time. The examples given

¹⁶“Desperate Rioting in Derry City; Detective and Ex-Soldier Dead; Many Wounded; Three Nights of Fierce Conflict; Masked Orangemen Hold up Passers-By.” *The Irish Independent*, Monday, May 17, 1920, 5.

¹⁷Ibid.

¹⁸““False as Usual”: Mr Griffith’s Comment on the Castle Denial.” *The Freeman’s Journal*, Saturday, June 26, 1920, 5.

¹⁹“Desperate Rioting in Derry City.” *The Irish Independent*, Monday, May 17, 1920, 5.

are not an exhaustive account of all that happened. This account demonstrates however, how ex-soldiers or war veterans featured in major street battles in Derry at that time. Furthermore, it gives the reader a sense of the intensity and frequency of violent episodes that led to the most violent and prolonged battle of all.

According to Liam Brady, who was a member of Na Fianna Éireann in 1920, a Protestant gentleman warned a republican officer in Derry that soldiers from the British Dorset Regiment were supplying rifles and ammunition to unionists so that they would cause a civil and religious war. The republican officer did not believe the story and took no action on the matter. This warning was given on Thursday June 17th, 1920.²⁰ Had the republican heeded the warning, the local republican movement might have been better prepared for what was soon to happen.

On the night of Friday 18th June some youths began arguing in Cross Street and Glendermott Road in the Waterside area of the city. The dispute happened because a unionist had been stopped by nationalists in Cross Street on the previous evening. The argument was not a serious one, but it was the ‘spark to the “powder mine,”’²¹ as Derry had been described earlier that week by a prominent Irish politician. It was,

²⁰ Liam A. Brady, “Derry riots, June 1920, St. Columba's College taken over by I.R.A. and Martial law called for by Derry Magistrates.” *Bureau of Military History 1913-21*, Document No. W.S.676, File No.S.1890, 47-52. (Hereafter Brady, *BMH* 47-52).

²¹ “Friday Night's Fierce Rioting; Catholic Houses Wrecked; People Driven from their Homes; Desperate Unionist Attacks.” *Derry Journal*, June 21, 1920, 3.

like the ball that rolled from Fountain Street down into Bridge Street, merely the excuse for the determined onslaught that came afterwards.²² As each day in June passed and each outbreak of violence happened, the intensity and severity increased greatly. Tension was escalating rapidly like a ball rolling down a steep street and gaining momentum as it rolled. Unionists mobilised in Glendermott Road and swooped down on Cross Street and Union Street. They attacked Catholics' houses and shops as well as the occupants of the buildings. Some police officers who were present when the attack began, left the scene and the unionist mob was able to vent its wrath unhindered. A middle-aged man and a six-year-old girl were shot and wounded. Some residents had to climb out of skylights and across roofs to escape to the countryside until morning. Some girls from Cross Street managed to get to the cityside and asked nationalists to mobilise and come to the assistance of their friends and families. Their request was heeded, and many nationalists tried to go to the Waterside to the aid of those under attack. Attempts to traverse the river by the bridge and by boat were repulsed by heavy gunfire from greater numbers of more heavily armed unionists. Some soldiers came into Cross Street and hostilities stopped briefly. The military presence was to ensure that one of their patrols could return to its base through the area. The soldiers from the Dorset's Regiment left and the pogroms resumed. However, at this point nationalists returned fire and unionist groups had to seek a degree of cover. Armed groups of unionists and nationalists took control of their areas and firing continued throughout the city on both sides of

²²"Friday Night's Fierce Rioting." *Derry Journal*, Monday, June 21, 1920, 3.

the river until six o'clock in the morning. On Saturday morning Cross Street and Union Street appeared as if an avenging army had passed through them. So great was the destruction.²³ The brief appearance of military in an area that was one hundred yards from the military base at Ebrington only to ensure that their military comrades did not get into difficulty returning to base shows that, at best they were indifferent to Catholic people being forced from their homes and physically attacked.

On the night of Saturday 19th June 1920, Jim Mc Veigh was standing at the top of Long Tower Street at the corner of Mullan's Bar with William Canning. At the time there was a crowd of people in Fountain Street. There had earlier been a fight between two drunk men at Bishop's Gate.²⁴ The fight had since broken up. A witness, James Ramsey, a former member of the Royal Air Force, who was standing at Breslin's corner claimed he saw a man called Robert Rankin standing at Brown's gateway in Fountain Street which was directly opposite Long Tower Street where Mc Veigh and Canning were standing. Ramsey claimed that Rankin was armed with a gun. Apprehensive that Rankin might use the gun, Ramsey shouted 'Rankin don't fire out of that. You're a marked man.' Ramsey claimed that almost immediately, Rankin fired down from Brown's gateway. The bullet entered the right side of Mc Veigh's neck and exited through his back at the level of the fifth rib. Mc Veigh

²³ *Ibd.*

²⁴ Brady, *BMH* 47-52.

staggered across to Martin's doorway and fell just short of Bishop's Gate. Several men including William Canning and James Ramsey rushed to Mc Veigh, picked him up and carried him through Bishop's Gate and into a house in Stable Lane. From there he was taken to the local infirmary where he was pronounced dead. At a subsequent trial, in which a young man called Robert Rankin, who was an ex-soldier²⁵ was acquitted without having to give any defence arguments, Ramsey and his evidence were discredited. The judge referred to Ramsey, who had about twelve previous convictions for petty crimes, as something of a corner boy. Rankin was acquitted and left the court smiling accompanied by some friends.²⁶ Jim Mc Veigh's three sons had served in the British army. One of them had been killed in France,²⁷ another was wounded, the third was still serving in Mesopotamia, while a son in law was serving in Persia.²⁸ An observation of this study is that many people who were victims or were alleged to have shot victims had former connections to the British army. Jim Mc Veigh had many family connections to the military. Ironically it was being alleged that he had been shot By Robert Rankin, himself a former soldier. What is more, Mc Veigh's son John, who fought with the 2nd Battalion Royal Inniskilling Fusiliers and whose name is recorded on the Le Touret Memorial, Pas de Calais, France and is also commemorated on the Diamond War Memorial, lived

²⁵ "The Derry Riots: Murder Charges Against Unionists." *The Liberator, Tralee*, Saturday July 3, 1920.

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²⁶ Ibid.

²⁷ Colm Fox, "Towards Partition."

²⁸ "Five Men Shot Dead in Derry: Many Citizens Seriously Wounded; Tragic Unionist Outburst; Desperate Street Fighting; Appalling Stories of Bloodshed and Brutality; Deplorable Scenes in William Street. *Derry Journal*, Monday, June 21, 1920, 3.

in 19 Albert Place with his wife Margaret and family when he was killed in action on May 15th, 1915.²⁹ It is unknown how long John and Margaret Mc Veigh were living there before his death. It is possible that they might have lived in the same street as Robert Rankin. Rankin and his family were living in 6 Albert Place in 1911.³⁰ The following short narrative piece is quoted verbatim because it supports a specific observation that this study wishes to illuminate.

A thrilling narrative of his gallant attempt at great risk to himself to get the Unionists to cease firing was given by an ex-soldier residing in Walker's Square. He said bullets were coming down as thick as hailstones, and women and children fainted in Walker's Square, and the fire was not being returned. In the interests of humanity, knowing that there were two persons lying dangerously ill with pneumonia in the street he decided to approach Fountain Street and appeal for a cessation of fire. With a white apron attached to a pole he, at imminent danger to his own life went up Long Tower Street. He does not know whether the signal was observed, but for about ten minutes firing ceased, only however, to be renewed again with an intensity unequalled in some of the hottest encounters of the Boer War, through which he fought. It was awful, he said to think that men who had been through the war should return to be shot like dogs in their homes without the least chance of defending themselves or their families.³¹

Notwithstanding that a woman, waving a white apron whilst going to the aid of the fatally wounded Thomas Mc Laughlin had been shot at and wounded a few hundred yards away at Butcher Street,³² this man's actions were either very brave or very reckless. His contribution displays contemporary sentiment in that many non-combatants with former military connections were shot dead or wounded in Derry's

²⁹"Private John McVeigh," *Diamond War Memorial Project*, Available:

<http://www.diamondwarmemorial.com/soldiers/view/850> [22 March 2018].

³⁰"Residents of a house 6.1 in Albert Place" (Londonderry No. 3 Urban, Londonderry), *Genealogy, The National Archives of Ireland*, Available:

http://www.census.nationalarchives.ie/pages/1911/Londonderry/Londonderry_No_3_Urban/Albert_Place/600063/ [23 March 2018].

³¹"Five Men Shot Dead in Derry." *Derry Journal*, Monday, June 21, 1920, 3.

³² Brady, *BMH* 47-52.

civil war. Bernard Doherty, Jim Mc Veigh and others who will be alluded to in this study had either been involved in the Great War, or family members had been involved in the Great War. Some returned home only to be shot or wounded, possibly by those who fought on the same side as them when they fought against the Boers, Germans or Turks. Others returned from the war to experience family members being killed by their former comrades whom they fought alongside in Flanders or The Dardanelles.

Fierce hand to hand fighting broke out in the city centre within the walled city following the shooting of James Mc Veigh in Long Tower Street. Fist fights broke out in Ferryquay Street, near Ferryquay Gate. Girls were seen at this location, fighting and pulling each other by the hair. A man punched a young boy to the ground in The Diamond and was subsequently pursued down Shipquay Street by women and youths where he took refuge in a club near Shipquay Gate. The crowd laid siege to the club, demanding access to the man. Unionists in Bishop Street began firing into the crowds in the Diamond and began advancing on the Diamond. Captain Stewart, a retired army officer was hit in the leg by this firing as he made his way to the Picture Palace in Shipquay Street.³³ The crowd in the Diamond scattered and most retreated down Butcher Street.³⁴

³³ "Five Men Shot Dead in Derry." *Derry Journal*, Monday, June 21, 1920, 3.

³⁴ *Ibid.*

Less than an hour after Mc Veigh had been shot, Thomas Mc Laughlin and some friends were returning from shipping a horse on the Scotch boat at the quay. They came to Butcher Street. They were warned that snipers were firing from The Diamond. The men ran across Butcher Street at Butcher's Gate. Mc Laughlin paused to look around and was shot dead at Butcher's Gate at 10pm. One of Mc Laughlin's friends saw six or seven men kneeling and armed with rifles across the top of Butcher Street at The Diamond. They appeared to have the streets in their possession.³⁵ A short time later at 10.20pm Edwin A. Price, from Canada was shot dead in his hotel at the Diamond.³⁶ Both Mc Laughlin and Price had been shot by an armed group of Orangemen who had marched over London Street and down Bishop Street, firing shots as they made their way to The Diamond. They were led by an ex-army

³⁵"Derry Riot Victims: Further Inquests." *The Irish Times*, June 30, 1920, 5.

³⁶ *Ibid.*



(Figure 1 Thomas Mc Loughlin shot dead at Butcher Gate on 19th June 1920).

sergeant.³⁷ Ironically, like the ex-army sergeant who led the armed Orangemen, Price was also an ex-soldier and an Orangeman.³⁸ Price had travelled from America to enlist with the Ambulance Corps of the Ulster Division and was soon to leave for America.³⁹ Ten minutes after Price was shot, Thomas Farren was shot dead in Long Tower Street where James Mc Veigh had been killed earlier.⁴⁰ Furthermore, Patrick Mallett was walking up towards the top of Long Tower Street just after 11 o' clock on the same night. There was a joint military and police presence at the top of the Long

³⁷ Brady, *BMH* 47-52.

³⁸ "Restoration of Order: Call by City Grand Orange Lodge." *Belfast News-Letter*, July 7, 1920, 5.

³⁹ "Appalling Scenes in Derry; Five Killed, Many Wounded; Desperate Rioting; Sequel to Two Nights Shooting." *The Irish Independent*, Monday June 21, 1920, 6.

⁴⁰ "Derry's Terrible Record; Inquest on Six Victims; Murder Verdicts; Sensational Evidence." *The Derry Journal*, Wednesday June 30, 1920, 3.

Tower Street at the time. A shot fired from Fountain Street hit Mallett and spun him around. Mallett shouted that he had been hit. Another man had tried to warn Mallett to walk no further towards Bishop Street, when suddenly the shot rang out and Mallett was hit. The crown forces did nothing although the shot was fired from behind their position. The wounded Mallett was conveyed to the City Infirmary in a trap where he died on 24th June 1920.⁴¹ What is more, on that same night, Saturday 19th June 1920 John Gallagher aged 19, was shot on Clarendon Street about 11-45pm.⁴² John Gallagher managed to crawl to the infirmary, but died of his wounds.⁴³ The death toll rose further overnight when James Doherty was shot dead outside Thomas Farren's wake in Long Tower Street at 5-30am on 20th June.⁴⁴ Numerous people were injured that night, many by gunfire. Some are listed in the local media as having been treated at the infirmary. Moreover, it was reported that so numerous were the injured that many were treated and passed through the infirmary so fast that their details were not recorded in medical logs.⁴⁵ Liam Brady argues that these killings were only a test to fathom what resistance might have come from the IRA and nationalist people. As there had been no resistance, as far as the armed Orangemen were concerned, the time was ripe for taking over the town. Moreover, Brady argues that the small number of Royal Irish Constabulary present in the city centre, moved

⁴¹ "Five Men Shot Dead in Derry." *Derry Journal*, Monday, June 21, 1920, 3

⁴² "Extra Troops Arrive but Derry Still in Chaos; Armoured Car in Action; Proclamation by Magistrates; The Death Toll." *Belfast Newsletter*, Thursday, June 24, 1920, 5.

⁴³ "The Derry Riots; Inquests on Victims; Startling Revelations." *Irish Examiner*, Tuesday, June 29, 1920, 5.

⁴⁴ Ibid.

⁴⁵ "Five Men Shot Dead in Derry." *Derry Journal*, Monday, June 21, 1920, 3

away to allow the attacks to proceed. There was no military or police intervention despite the fact that a Battalion of the Dorset's Regiment and hundreds of police were stationed in barracks in the town at that time.⁴⁶ The trouble spread to William Street where rioting continued throughout the night. Unionist owned businesses were looted and torched. IRA or Irish Volunteers were deployed to police the areas and prevent attacks on Unionist businesses.⁴⁷

Sunday 20th June was reasonably quiet although wild rumours abounded. As Sunday passed into Monday 21st June, in the 'early hours Joseph Mc Glinchey, son of an ex-soldier, was shot through the head in Long Tower Street and was conveyed to the Infirmary in a dying condition. A man named Brown had his arms shattered and sustained a wound in the body at the same place'.⁴⁸ Joseph Mc Glinchey had been shot through the head at Long Tower Street on the morning of 21st June and died at the Infirmary on 27th June 1920 from shock and meningitis. According to Sergeant Walker of the RIC, on the morning of the 21st June, at 5.15am, he was made aware that a man had been shot at Bishop's Gate. Walker went to the scene immediately, accompanied by four colleagues. They found there a young man sitting against a wall at the corner of Long Tower Street, at Mullan's corner (Mullan's Bar). The boy

⁴⁶ Brady, *BMH* 47-52.

⁴⁷ Ibid.

⁴⁸ Derry Fighting; State of Civil War; Many Casualties. *The Western Daily Press: Bristol*; June 22, 1920, 10.

was wounded in the head and his breathing was slow. He was unconscious. The sergeant lifted the boy in his arms and carried him to the safety of Mullan's Bar doorway. There was a pool of blood where he had been sitting. Sergeant Walker found a rifle bullet in the pool of blood. This was produced at the inquest. Sergeant Walker sent one of his colleagues to fetch a priest. The priest arrived and attended to the young boy. The boy was taken to Ramsey's house in Walker's Square.

Ramsay got a cart and delivered the boy to the Infirmary. Ramsay had heard no shots from Long Tower Street, but he did hear shots from Fountain Street. Beside where the boy was lying, he noticed a hole in the gable wall about three inches wide and two inches deep. In his opinion, the only way the shot could have come was from Fountain Street direction. He noticed a slight wound on the boy's forehead and a powerful gash on the back of his head. Other witnesses gave similar accounts to Walker and Ramsey's. It was concluded that the culprit or culprits who fired the fatal shot were guilty of murder. However, despite condemnation from the jury,



Figure 2 Joseph Mc Glinchey. Shot dead in Long Tower Street 21/6/1920 (courtesy Mc Glinchey Family).

coroner and solicitor, the culprits were unknown. Joseph's death, it was concluded was caused by shock and meningitis.⁴⁹ James Mc Glinchey from Nelson Street, father of Joseph, said his son was fifteen years and four months old. James Mc Glinchey, before the Great War was a prominent officer in the Irish Volunteers. He was known as Commander Mc Glinchey.⁵⁰

At approximately the same time Joseph Mc Glinchey was shot, James Dobbin, a unionist carter was making his way to work on the morning of June 21st, 1920 when he was approached by a number of men at the bottom of Bridge Street at the junction with John Street. He was beaten and shot in the chest. He was then dragged, his head bumping along on stone setts all the way to the river. He was thrown into the river and left lying in the mud because it was at low tide. He was later rescued by Reilly, a railway worker. He suffered from scalp wounds, a broken back, effects of being submerged in the river and a bullet wound to a lung. He died after ten days in the infirmary. Following his death, his widow gave birth to a child. That child died after six weeks. His widow died shortly after that, leaving their remaining child an orphan.⁵¹ Hugh Mc Feely and Robert Doyle from Bridge Street were brought to trial for killing Dobbin. They were acquitted after being tried three times.⁵² Mc Feely

⁴⁹ "Murder of Young Mc Glinchey: Fatal Shots from Fountain Street." *The Derry Journal*, July 7, 1920, 6.

⁵⁰ Brady, *BMH* 47-52.

⁵¹ "Gunmen's Triple Murder; £1,000 Compensation Awarded to Protestant Orphan; Echo of Derry Crime." *Belfast Newsletter*, Thursday, October 13, 1921, 5.

⁵² *The Irish Independent*, Saturday June 11, 1921.

had served in the British army and navy.⁵³ Once charges were brought against these men, they became part of the events of that week in June. Whether or not they were involved in Dobbin's killing, they are now written into the narrative of the events.

By Monday 21st June, Derry people thought that the violence had settled enough so that they could go to work, notwithstanding the fact that a young boy and a young man had been shot and seriously wounded in the early hours of the morning. As nationalist Dockers set about their duties at the quay and girls made their way to the factories, riflemen opened fire from the Waterside area on the east bank of the Foyle. In addition to this, it soon became apparent that large bodies of riflemen had positioned themselves on the roofs of commercial buildings, strategically chosen to command views of large geographical areas of the town. Snipers on Sam Taggart's flat roof on John Street, controlled the Carlisle Bridge. Moreover, these snipers on Taggart's roof controlled John Street, Foyle Road, Abercorn Road, the lower end of Bridge Street, and part of Foyle Street. The snipers on the roof of Frew's Hotel on Carlisle Road controlled Orchard Street, part of Bridge Street, Market Street and a large portion of Derry Walls. Snipers took up positions in several historic buildings and on monuments because they overlooked most of the nationalist areas on the west bank of the Foyle. Governor George Walker's Monument on the city walls, Saint Columb's Cathedral in Bishop Street, the Orange Hall and the Masonic Hall

⁵³ "Cruel Derry Murders; Prisoners on Trial." *The Cork Examiner*, Thursday December 9, 1920, 5.

in Magazine Street all bristled with rifles borne by members of the Ulster Volunteer Force. These positions were occupied by Williamite defenders during the Great Siege of 1688 to 1689. The unionists in 1920 had chosen to wage war from the same battlements their siege heroes had done two centuries earlier.⁵⁴ Across the river in the Waterside area, the situation was much the same. Nationalist enclaves at Cross Street, Irish Street and Chapel Road were attacked. A group of armed Orangemen took up positions at the top of King Street one hundred yards from the Ebrington military base. There were no attempts by the military to challenge them. Expert signalers using Morse code and semaphore communicated between the Cityside and Waterside of Derry to co-ordinate their activities. These activities left Liam Brady in no doubt that it was a well organised affair backed by the British government rather than the activities of a group of irresponsible youths.⁵⁵

The Irish Volunteers in Derry had been depleted by arrests and because many volunteers had gone elsewhere in search of work. Previously a group of volunteers known as the Ten Foot Pikers or the TFP were active in weapons procurement by seizing unionists' personal weapons collections. They were also involved in political operations like neutralising unionists' postal votes as elections approached. Michael Sheerin and Alfie Mc Callion began re-organising the volunteers in May 1920. The two men were walking up Bishop Street in June 1920, probably on the night Mc

⁵⁴ Carlo Gébler, *The Siege of Derry*. (Great Britain: Little, Brown, 2005), 176-194.

⁵⁵ Brady, *BMH* 47-52.

Veigh and the other several men were killed. Shots were being fired from Fountain Street into Bishop Street. They became aware of the killings and wounding there and then. They decided to mobilise their unit and called a meeting of the volunteers in The Shamrock Hall in the Bogside. Amid the excitement, many volunteers and lapsed volunteers arrived at the hall. They and Cumann na mBann female volunteers paraded, armed and took up positions in Saint Columba's College on Bishop Street. The volunteers were welcomed by 'the priests who were the Dean, Fr. James McGlinchey, and the President, Dr McShane. Both these priests were in the Sinn Fein organisation and were two fine Irish priests.'⁵⁶ What is more, a mobilization of I.R.A. took place in the Owen Roe Hall, off Bishop Street, on Sunday night, 20th June to consider how they would protect the nationalist people of Derry. The volunteers paraded and all those who had any guns with them or at home were asked to take a step forward. About 15 stepped forward. Two had rifles and the rest had revolvers, some of which were obsolete with no compatible ammunition. It was clear that the I.R.A. had not expected the sudden outbreak of violent attacks by the Orangemen and were not prepared for it. A discussion followed to discern the cause of the shooting. It became clear that the Orangemen were being used by the British Government to start sectarian strife in the north of Ireland. The I.R.A. were ordered to take stern measures against the armed Orangemen. Moreover, they were to

⁵⁶ Michael Sheerin, *Bureau of Military History 1913-21*, Document No. W.S. 803, File No. S.2114.



Figure 3 Saint Columba's College, Bishop Street.

protect the lives and property of all citizens, including unionists. 'This they did, to the best of their ability.'⁵⁷ The rationale for the IRA's taking possession of St. Columba's College was because they saw it as a military position.⁵⁸ The general area of Bishop Street in Derry is built on a hill formerly known as Windmill Hill. Windmill Hill got the name because of a Windmill which is situated in Saint Columba's College's grounds. It was a strategic position chosen by the Jacobites during the siege of 1688 to 1689. The IRA and the UVF were in the same positions where their predecessors had done battle. The 20th century Battle of Windmill Hill

⁵⁷ Brady, *BMH* 47-52.

⁵⁸ *Ibid.*

was about to commence. St. Columba's overlooked some of their enemies' strongholds and enabled them to beat them out of their strongholds with casualties, both dead and wounded on the enemy side, according to Dominic Doherty, an IRA activist stationed in Saint Columba's College.⁵⁹ Seamus Mc Cann was given instructions by the local IRA commander, Paddy Shiels to go to Scalp Mountain in nearby Donegal and pick up two Colt machine guns and a few thousand rounds of ammunition. They delivered these to the College and handed them over to the officer in charge there. These weapons and ammunition according to Mc Cann were 'Redmond Volunteer equipment.'⁶⁰ All available arms were collected as other groups of men were sent to collect weapons where it was known they were available, and the college organised into a defensive position. Two machineguns had been displayed by the Irish National Volunteers for the first time on a route march led by Commander Mc Glinchey on September 27th, 1914.⁶¹ This acquisition of two machineguns and other weapons from the Redmondite Volunteers came at around the time that Commander Mc Glinchey's young son, Joseph lay gravely ill with a bullet through his skull James Mc Glinchey was founder and Commander of Irish Volunteers in Derry c.1912-1922.⁶² Commander Mc Glinchey in his senior position must have given his permission for these weapons transactions that greatly increased the IRA's firepower.

⁵⁹ Dominic Doherty, *Bureau of Military History 1913-21*, Document No. W.S. 846, File No. S.2093.

⁶⁰ Seamus Mc Cann, *Bureau of Military History 1913-21*, Document No. W.S. 763, File No. S.1647.

⁶¹ "Irish Volunteers' Route March." *The Derry Journal*, Monday, September 28, 1914, 2.

⁶² James Mc Glinchey's Headstone Inscription in Derry City Cemetery.

The two machine guns were brought into play on some Orangemen who had constructed a barricade across Bishop Street connecting Abercorn Road with Barrack Street. Fighting was then taking place in the Nationalist areas which in some cases were occupied by detachments from the college. Johnnie Fox's house off Howard Street in the Long Tower precinct was used in the defence of the areas.⁶³ Republicans in the college had control of several streets surrounding the college. Sniping was widespread. Peculiarly the British authorities did not interfere for a number of days. All the time there was heavy firing between the IRA and the UVF. According to Mc Cann:

‘It was only when the Volunteers had got into a position which enabled them to hit back with effect that military reinforcements were sent into Derry. The British military authorities, strange to say, didn't adopt an impartial attitude in their efforts to stop the riots. In every instance where they interfered, their attention was always directed towards the Nationalist forces. When armoured cars had arrived in Derry and when they made efforts to surround the College, we were ordered to evacuate, which we did.’⁶⁴

Patrick Sheils was a ubiquitous senior IRA officer in Derry City. He embodied the policy of the ballot box in one hand and a revolver in the other. He had, in partnership with the veteran election campaigner and nationalist registration agent, Michael McDaid worked vigorously in the Revision Courts where objections to votes on the register were heard. Their hard work ensured the maximum nationalist and

⁶³ Seamus Mc Cann, *BMH*.

⁶⁴ *Ibid*.

republican performance.⁶⁵ Moreover, he was imprisoned shortly afterwards for threatening police with a revolver during a house raid.⁶⁶ Furthermore, Shiels was on hunger strike in Mountjoy Gaol in April 1920. On Monday 21st June he led a body of armed volunteers up Waterloo Street in Derry to Butcher's Gate, where unionists had shot and killed or wounded nationalists on the previous Saturday night. The UVF had control of the Diamond at the time. Shiels' volunteers each fired one shot into the Diamond and succeeded in dislodging the unionists who feared they were under attack from a greater number of republicans. The unionists retreated to Fountain Street without returning fire.⁶⁷ Shiels arrived in the Saint Columba's College the next day and assumed command from Michael Sheerin who had been directing operations until then. Paddy Shiels' reputation was suitable for the role of commanding Saint Columba's College.⁶⁸ The IRA or Irish Volunteers as they were known, had been weak and taken by surprise. Once they had assessed the situation, made tactical decisions and acquired the appropriate materials, they were ready to launch a counter-offensive.

Unfortunately for a young man named Howard Mc Kay, he was about to become the next person to die. Howard Mc Kay was shot dead at the North West Showgrounds on Lone Moore Road at about 3pm on the afternoon of Monday 21st

⁶⁵ Fox, *The Making of a Minority*.

⁶⁶ Ibid.

⁶⁷ Brady, *BMH*.

⁶⁸ Sheerin, *BMH*.

June 1920. Howard Mc Kay was a soldier in the British army and the son of Marshall Mc Kay, the Governor of the Apprentice Boys of Derry.⁶⁹ Two men named James Keenan and James Hillen were charged with his killing at a special court in Derry on November 7th, 1923. James Keenan was involved in the gun battles to protect the nationalist people that week.⁷⁰ It was claimed in court that Mc Kay had faced a mock court-martial. His execution was real however, and his remains were left lying on the roadside until picked up by a passing hearse and delivered to his father's home at Termonbacca on the outskirts of the city. The chief witness against the two men was a youth who had been raised as a Catholic, converted to Protestantism and joined the C Specials, a division of the Ulster Special Constabulary. The witness declared that he was at the showgrounds on the day Mc Kay was killed. Moreover, according to his evidence, Mc Kay was held captive by the two accused and Johnnie Farren, a man called Mc Gee and a girl called Sweeney. The group of captors were armed with three revolvers and a rifle. They questioned Mc Kay about the whereabouts of Ulster Volunteer rifles. Mc Kay said that he would not tell them. The captors argued about allowing Mc Kay to leave. Keenan threatened to shoot Hillen if he were to release Mc Kay. Mc Kay was then blindfolded by Hillen using a white handkerchief. Furthermore, Hillen placed Mc Kay against a wall and the captors stood back from him. They chased potential witnesses, at one stage Farren fired a warning shot. The witness and others ran a short distance but returned after

⁶⁹ "70th anniversary of leading Derry republican's death to be marked." *Derry Journal Online*, Friday November 8, 2013. Available: <https://www.derryjournal.com/news/70th-anniversary-of-leading-derry-republican-s-death-to-be-marked-1-5665917> [2 April 2018].

⁷⁰ Ibid.

hearing a shot. On his return he saw Mc Kay lying on the roadside. The white handkerchief was bloodied, there were cards lying on Mc Kay's body, the male captors had fled, and the girl Sweeney was kicking and jumping on Mc Kay as he lay there. Neither of the two accused admitted the charges. They were remanded in custody to a later date.⁷¹ The accused men went on trial three times and were acquitted three times of Mc Kay's killing. Keenan was the Irish Republican Army's Derry Battalion Quartermaster from 1921. He was imprisoned again in the 1930s. He remained a member of the IRA until his death in 1943. Many of his descendants were members of the IRA and Sinn Féin and remain linked to the republican movement in Derry to the present day. James Keenan, prior to the Mc Kay killing had 'fought in the First World War before returning to Derry and becoming involved in the IRA.'⁷² James Keenan was an IRA activist and was involved in republican activism during this period. It is not the intention of this study to attempt to ascertain the guilt or innocence of those who were accused in court of killing the deceased. However, James Keenan was an ex-British soldier who was involved as a republican soldier, fighting against his former British army comrades who were Ulster Volunteers in Derry's own week long civil war in the summer of 1920.

⁷¹ *The Freeman's Journal*, Thursday, November 8, 1923, 7.

⁷² Brian Lacey and Tommy Carlin, *Easter 1916, From the GPO to Free Derry: Stories and Reflections from Derry*, (2016), (Derry: Coiste Dhoire 1916-2016, 2016), 150.

William O' Kane was not involved in the fighting but was merely on his way to work in the Midland Railway Company along with a fellow worker called Mc Loone at 7.30am on Tuesday 22nd June. According to Mc Loone, they were walking along Spencer Road towards the Bridge when they noticed a man about two hundred yards away on the opposite side of the street. When he got closer he crossed over and walked past them and then called after them, ordering them to stop. He had a revolver in his right hand. He asked them what they were. After telling him they were going to work and that they were railway workers, he asked their religion. When Mc Loone replied that they were Roman Catholic the man fired a shot, grazing Mc Loone's neck. The two railway men turned and ran towards Fountain Hill. The assailant fired a further four or five rounds one of which went through O' Kane's back and lodged in his breast. O'Kane subsequently collapsed, and Mc Loone caught him and eased him to the ground. Moreover, Mc Loone's evidence was corroborated by a postman called Logue. Several others witnessed portions of the event and some heard the rapid burst of shots. The wounded man was carried into a nearby house. A doctor was summoned, but O' Kane died at around nine o' clock. An ex-soldier in the Royal Inniskilling Fusiliers, called James Gray later went on trial the following December for the shooting. Gray had lost his left arm when he was seriously wounded during the Battle of The Somme on 1st July 1916. Several witnesses appeared on behalf of Gray, stating that he had spent the entire night in Victoria Orange Hall. The alibi witnesses stated that Gray was among one hundred men who had stayed the night in the hall. There were seven rifles there. All doors to the hall

were locked and one man had the keys. He would have known if anyone had left the hall. According to him and several others, Gray did not leave the hall until near 8am, after O’Kane had been shot. The purpose of the lock-in was that the men would have defended the hall if there had been an attempt by opponents to attack it. Gray’s exemplary character, his war record and the fact that his father was a respectable prominent unionist were all illuminated during the trial. Gray was acquitted. The announcement was greeted with rapturous applause and an ovation as he left the court.⁷³ James Gray whether he was guilty or innocent of killing William O’ Kane, was a loyalist activist. He was involved in Derry’s civil war. He was part of a group of approximately one hundred activists who stayed overnight in an Orange Hall. There were several rifles available to these men to carry out their activism. He was highly praised for his war activities at the Somme where he was injured resulting in the loss of an arm. It is unlikely that if the need had arisen for the defence of the Orange Hall, that he could have used a rifle. However, he was technically in possession of these firearms, yet it was his alibi and he walked free. Later the same night that O’ Kane was shot dead Patrick J.Plunkett received a bullet wound through the abdomen and then through his left arm. His body lay where it fell on Bishop Street for two nights and a day from 8.30pm on the Tuesday night 22nd June to 7.30am on the Thursday 24th June 1920. Plunkett was a native of Belfast who conducted business as a commercial traveler in Derry.⁷⁴

⁷³ *The Weekly Telegraph*, December 11, 1920. 7

⁷⁴ “Man’s Inhumanity to Man: Body Two Nights and a Day on Street.” *The Derry Journal*, July 7,

As Plunkett's remains lay on Bishop Street, Albert Duff, a resident of Ferguson Street, off Lower Bishop Street heard a shot, on the evening of June 23rd. A short time later he saw Mrs. Margaret Mills coming down Ferguson Street holding her left shoulder. She began to fall, but another man ran over and caught her as she fell. Duff helped bring her into his house, where she died within five minutes. She remained unconscious from the time she collapsed in the street. According to Duff, shooting had continued throughout that day in Bishop Street. Thomas Davis, of Ferguson Street, gave a similar account. He said Mrs. Mills, 'was sinking on the street when he got hold of her.'⁷⁵ Davis did not see who fired the shot. However, he indicated that it must have 'come from the foot of Bishop Street, judging from the position the woman was in and the nature of her wound.'⁷⁶ Davis was adamant that the shot that killed her did not come across the Foyle from the Waterside because she was facing down Bishop Street and received the wound in the breast. Charles Hegarty, another Ferguson Street resident and witness at Margaret Mills' inquest, saw Mrs. Mills walking up Ferguson Street in the direction of Bishop Street. Hegarty disagreed with a juror named Hutchinson that the shot could have come from the Waterside. He maintained that it came from Lower Bishop Street. There was further disagreement when Hutchinson suggested it would be necessary to get a map to

1920, 6.

⁷⁵ "The Derry Horror: Gruesome Inquest Details; Ghouls at Work; Terrible Acts of Brutality; Murder of Five Catholics; Death of Mrs Mills; Shots up Bishop Street." *The Derry Journal*, July 7, 1920, 6.

⁷⁶ Ibid.

show whether it was possible. The Coroner stated that there would be no maps and that the inquest was to establish the cause of death. Other circumstances were for another type of tribunal. Mills' death was caused by shock and haemorrhage, inflicted by a rifle bullet wound on the chest. The jury found that she was murdered by a person or persons unknown. Sympathy was extended to her husband and family. Mrs Mills' son, 'Private Thomas Alexander Mills, Royal Marine Light Infantry, Plymouth Battalion, Royal Naval Division, was killed in action on May 3, 1915, while serving at the Dardanelles.'⁷⁷ She lived in Orchard Row with her husband Alex, who had been decorated for service during the South African War with his regiment, the 1st Inniskilling Fusiliers. 'Maggie and Alexander Mills, 6, Orchard Row, signed the Ulster Solemn League and Covenant (September 1912) pledging resistance to Home Rule for Ireland.'⁷⁸ Her other son Robert had served in the Royal Inniskilling Fusiliers⁷⁹ and later served in the Ulster Special Constabulary and was based in Claudy, County Derry.⁸⁰ It was argued at her inquest that the fatal shot came from Lower Bishop Street. Lower Bishop Street below Ferguson Street is the location of Saint Columba's College, a position held during the battle, by nationalists and republicans. The barricade on the street outside the college was staffed mainly by

⁷⁷ "Private Thomas Alexander Mills," *Diamond War Memorial Project*, Available: <http://www.diamondwarmemorial.com/soldiers/view/88528> [13 April 2018].

⁷⁸ "Private Thomas Alexander Mills," *Diamond War Memorial Project*.

⁷⁹ "Roll of Honour 1914-1919: Extract for the Congregation of Derry: Ebrington." *Eddie's Extracts. Presbyterian Church in Ireland*, Available: <http://www.eddiesextracts.com/rohpci/rohderryebrington.html> [13 April 2018].

⁸⁰ "Private Thomas Alexander Mills," *Diamond War Memorial Project*.

nationalist ex-servicemen.⁸¹ It is possible from these accounts that ironically, the shot that hit Mrs. Mills may have come from a group of fighters who had fought in the British armed forces like her sons and her husband.

Earlier on Wednesday 23rd June 1920 before Mrs. Mills was killed, three other people had been killed. They were: John Mc Kinney who was shot at 7-30am on 23rd June 1920 at Clooney Terrace in the Waterside and died 9-00 on 24th June,⁸² William Rankin was shot in the chest at the Barrack Street junction with Bishop Street at 11.30am and died at 6.30pm on 23rd June,⁸³ and Peter Campbell who was shot in a rowing boat whilst trying to cross the river at 2.15pm on the afternoon of the 23rd June 1920.⁸⁴ As mentioned above, Mrs. Mills was killed later that evening. However, the following day there followed a further four deaths before that week's carnage came to an end.

Elizabeth Moore was shot when she opened her front door on Bishop Street at 7.30am on Thursday June 24th. She expired on June 30th from shock and

⁸¹ Sheerin, *BMH*.

⁸² "The Derry Inquests; Murder of Catholics; Long Tower Street Slaughter; Demand for Government Grant." *The Derry Journal*, Friday, July 9, 1920, 5.

⁸³ "Three More Inquests: Twentieth Victim; Murder Verdict in Each Case." *The Derry Journal*, July 2, 1920, 7.

⁸⁴ *Ibid*.

haemorrhage.⁸⁵ Robert Mc Laughlin was shot outside his family's home at 99 Bishop Street by unionists staffing a barricade at Barrack Street. His body lay for several hours before it was recovered.⁸⁶ At 1pm that afternoon, George Caldwell, an eight-year-old orphan was shot dead as he looked out of his window towards the Foyle Road in Nazareth House Nunnery and Home.⁸⁷ Notwithstanding that many victims lay gravely ill and did succumb to their injuries later that week, the final victim to be shot in Derry's week long civil war was an Englishman named Augustus Austin.

Augustus Austin was an ex-British soldier who had converted to Catholicism. He was staying with his family at Cross Street in the Waterside area of Derry. He had been wounded three times whilst in the army. It appears that Austin was something of a hate figure to local unionists because he changed his religion. He was shot in Union Street at 7pm on the evening of 24th June 1920. Austin's wife was at home at the time of the shooting. She heard the shot and ran to her front door, saying "That is a deadly shot. Someone belonging to me has been killed". When Mrs. Austin went into the street, she saw her husband being pulled into Mrs. Murphy's house at number 15 Union Street. She went into Mrs. Murphy's and tried to speak to her husband. She asked if he was dying. He lay on the floor unconscious and did not

⁸⁵ "Three More Inquests: Twentieth Victim; Murder Verdict in Each Case." *The Derry Journal*, July 2, 1920, 7.

⁸⁶ "The Derry Horror: Gruesome Inquest Details; Ghouls at Work; Terrible Acts of Brutality; Murder of Five Catholics; Death of Mrs Mills; Shots up Bishop Street." *The Derry Journal*, July 7, 1920, 6.

⁸⁷ "Orphan Boy Murdered: The Nazareth House Tragedy". *The Derry Journal*, July 7th, 1920, 6.

speaking. He died within half an hour. He had earlier left his home at 6.15pm. Joseph Mc Ginley from Cross Street ran to help the wounded man after hearing a shot and seeing him fall. He and William Quinn helped carry him into Murphy's house. Mc Ginley found a rifle bullet beside Austin's body. It was a service bullet, in other words it came from a British army service rifle. Mc Ginley believed the shot came from Blair's corner at the bottom of Bond Street. Moreover, Bella Mulhern, also from Cross Street had seen a man with something in his hand at Blair's Corner before the shooting. The man was waving a crowd back from the corner. Although Mulhern felt she could identify the man, she could not say what was in his hand. Austin's wife said at his inquest that: "They sniped at my husband from Bond's Street until they got him".⁸⁸ Austin had lived at 33 John Street. The house was owned by a Protestant family. The owner received a letter a week prior to the killing demanding that he should clear out the "turncoat" or be shot on sight. The previous Friday night the house was attacked by about three hundred unionists. Austin escaped death on that occasion when police escorted him to safety. His attackers believed he was under arrest. Austin and his family from that Friday onwards took refuge in John Mulhern's house. The house was from then the target of incessant sniping from unionist strongholds. The family could not leave the house. On the night of his death, Austin and his brother in law left the house to get supplies. According to *The Freeman's Journal* 'When Austin turned the corner he was shot dead by a unionist sniper who

⁸⁸ "Where Row Started. Murderers Lie in Wait for a Convert." *The Derry Journal*, July 7th, 1920.

occupied a position in a shed behind the residence of a prominent local Unionist.’⁸⁹ Augustus Austin had been a target from the beginning of Derry’s Civil War, possibly before it. The reason was that he had changed his religion. More than two hundred and thirty years earlier another Englishman converted to Catholicism. That conversion caused a civil war that started in Derry. He too was fired on in Derry. His name was King James II.⁹⁰

British reinforcements were brought into the city to oppose the IRA in Saint Columba’s College. The British government sent thousands of troops with armoured cars, Lewis guns and machineguns and the additional support of a battleship in the River Foyle.⁹¹ The IRA in the college decided that the time had come to evacuate. Machine guns were being played on their positions. The armoured cars encircled the republican positions and by machine-gun fire destroyed most of their street barricades. Those barricades were made of sandbags, bags of flour, and bags of sugar. The British machine-gun fire quickly annihilated those defences. ‘Eventually the personnel manning the outer defences who were mainly ex-British soldiers with a national background were dislodged and came into the College, handed over their arms and were sent home.’⁹² Liam Brady reveals the IRA’s evacuation strategy:

⁸⁹ “A Typical Murder: Provider of a Wife and Family of Three.” *The Freeman’s Journal*, Saturday, June 26, 1920, 5.

⁹⁰ Carlo Gebler, 156.

⁹¹ “Irish Affairs.” *Oamaru Mail*, Volume XLIV, Issue 14723, 25 June 1920.

⁹² Sheerin, *BMH*.

The IRA ordered their Forces to disperse quietly and to take up their usual occupations as they were not going to let the British trick them into a full-scale attack where they would be outnumbered both in men and material. Their arms and ammunition were collected and taken safely back to their dumps while a few men with revolvers were stationed at the various points for the protection of Churches and Streets that were in the danger zone.

The use of ships supporting combatants in Derry also featured in other periods of military conflict. Captain Percy Kirk's fleet waited in the Foyle during the 1688-89 siege until they eventually sailed forward and lifted the siege.⁹³ Moreover, a major British army operation known as Operation Motorman in July 1972 also deployed battleships in the Foyle to support land forces when they moved into the no-go areas of Derry.⁹⁴ Many of the IRA activists involved in the battles of this civil war became members of a flying column and fought against crown forces in County Donegal during the remainder of the War of Independence.⁹⁵

⁹³ Carlo Gébler, 280-298.

⁹⁴ Smith, M. L. R. and Neumann, Peter R. (2005) 'Motorman's Long Journey: Changing the Strategic Setting in Northern Ireland', *Contemporary British History*, 19: 4, 413 — 435

⁹⁵ Liam O' Duibhir, *The Donegal Awakening* (Cork: Mercier Press, 2009), 202.



Figure 4 A mural expressing hatred for the Dorsets and support for the IRA. It likens the battles of 1920 to Dublin 1916.

Evidence illuminated throughout this study has squarely made the case that crown forces, especially the British army supported the unionists. ‘The identification of the crown forces with the UVF was endemic and had been the case since the force was founded.’⁹⁶ Pearse Lawlor and Colm Fox both note the fraternising relationship between the UVF and the Dorset Regiment. Lawlor asserts that ‘because there were ex-servicemen among UVF ranks, they were able to persuade the British soldiers in the city to side with them.’⁹⁷ Fox draws attention to how because of ‘the partisan behaviour of the army in openly fraternising with armed Unionist killers and looters, some RIC officers threatened to resign and complained bitterly to the military authorities.’⁹⁸ An incident in Derry during the heavy fighting supports their argument that there was collusion. Two brothers, Patrick and Andrew O’ Connor were arrested during heavy firing between nationalists and unionists. The latter now supported by the British army. On the 23rd June soldiers accompanied by armed UVF men rushed the house where they were staying. They were accused of being snipers although no weapons were found. Empty bullet cases were found in a search the following day, but nothing was found on the night they were arrested although the house had been searched then too. The men were acquitted but attention was drawn as to why the soldiers did not disarm the armed UVF personnel. The resident magistrate expressed his disapproval saying: ‘The soldiers had seen rifles in the hands of civilians, according to the evidence, and had not interfered. That of course,

⁹⁶ Lawlor, *Outrages*, 42-45.

⁹⁷ Lawlor, *Outrages*, 15.

⁹⁸ Fox, *The Making of a Minority*.

was absolutely wrong. The men should have been deprived of their arms.’ A Staff Officer, Captain Jones informed the hearing that the military authorities had issued an order that anyone found to be in possession of firearms should be apprehended.⁹⁹ James Gray was freed by a court although he gave an alibi stating that he was part of a group in an Orange Hall in possession of seven rifles.¹⁰⁰ However, by the Autumn of that year, rather than being apprehended, the illegally armed unionists became legally armed and uniformed as members of the Ulster Special Constabulary.¹⁰¹

This study has traced chronologically the events in Derry during the spring and summer of 1920. The events became known as the June Riots or the Derry Civil War. The sectarian division and hatred in the north of Ireland instilled by the Ulster Plantation has withstood the test of time. This study has illuminated the laager mentality of Ulster unionists especially in Derry with its siege history. The reasons behind the outbreaks of violence were because of changes in the local political landscape. A fear existed in unionism that Derry might become part of the Irish Free State. A well-planned operation was implemented by unionists to prevent that happening. Force was readily used. It was two years after the end of the Great War. Evidentially many men in the city had seen active service in the British army. Twenty-two people were killed in May and June 1920. Many more were injured,

⁹⁹ “Who Were the Snipers? Soldiers Strange Evidence; Charge Against Two Catholics Dismissed.” *The Derry Journal*, Friday, July 2, 1920, 7.

¹⁰⁰ *The Weekly Telegraph*, December 11, 1920, 7.

¹⁰¹ Lawlor, *Outrages*, 42-45.

possibly hundreds. As a case study, eight of the victims' killings were examined because there were former military connections either attributable to the victims or to those accused of killing them. In some cases, both the victim and the accused had links to recent military service in the British armed forces. A stark example was the James Mc Veigh case. Mc Veigh had three sons and a son in law in the military. One was killed and one wounded. The man who was accused of killing Mc Veigh was a former soldier and the man who claimed to have recognised him was himself a former member of the crown forces. Men who had fought on the same side, in the same war, and in the same armed forces were fighting gun battles against each other in their native town. It is noteworthy that in many of the shootings, the victims were killed by a single aimed shot rather than by a sustained volley. This demonstrates the military prowess of some of those carrying out the shootings and how they coolly chose specific targets. This was especially noticeable in the shootings of Mc Veigh, Mills and Austin. Austin's wife claimed that they had been sniping at him until they got him. The chosen locations for the fighting were historical locations. The unionists were in the same positions as the besieged Williamites during the siege of 1688 and 1689. The IRA on the other hand assumed the position the Jacobites held during the siege. They again fought the Battle of Windmill Hill. The 1920 battle had its roots in the seventeenth century because King James II's decision to install Cormac O' Neill as mayor back in 1688 had been overturned by the Williamites before the siege. For the first time in centuries the Williamite decision was reversed and it led firstly to riots, pogroms and eventually to a short but bloody urban

guerrilla war. Many members of the armed squads who went on the offensive, killing, wounding, beating and shooting Derry citizens in the spring and summer of 1920 were policing them by the winter. Moreover, they were permitted do so for fifty years thereafter.

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